Art or Artifact

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

1 **Identify the Source**	When was this piece of art or artifact (a historical object) created?
	Where was it created?
	Who created it?
2 **Place the Source in Context**	What's the historical context of this piece of art or artifact?
	Was it created for purposes of entertainment or aesthetics? Or is it something functional?
	Are there markings or other indications of its origin?
3 **Analyze the Source Content**	If this is a piece of art, what does it portray?
	If this is an artifact, what was its purpose?
4 **Assess the Source Perspective**	If this is a piece of art, what medium did the artist use to express herself or himself?
	If this is a piece of art, what biases or perspectives did the artist have?
	Was the creator trying to motivate or convince people?
	If this is an artifact, what do you think were the reasons for its creation and use?
	If this is an artifact, what does it tell you about the individual and society who created it?
5 **Evaluate the Source**	If this is a piece of art, how do you think viewers reacted to it? How do you react to it?
	If this is an artifact, do you think it was a useful one? How so?
	Why was this art or artifact important to the people who created and used it, and why is it important now for what it can tell us?
	What connections can you make from it to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, and historical change over time?
	Does comparing this art or artifact with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight?
	Can you tie this art or artifact into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates?